StoryCast: Research and Documentation

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Links: Figma wireframes:
https://www.figma.com/design/xN0TxCKxJGeBxihTukHvuS/StoryCast-Design?node-id=3-20&p=f&t=BCdSVxTZyEknq78Q-0

Figma high-fidelity mockups:
https://www.figma.com/design/xN0TxCKxJGeBxihTukHvuS/StoryCast-Design?node-id=3-21&p=f&t=BCdSVxTZyEknq78Q-0

GitHub repository: https://github.com/prince-nda/storycast

1. Project overview

StoryCast is a three-page accessible microsite for audio and video storytelling. It shows short stories from real voices and makes them easy to find, watch, listen to, and read. The site is built with plain HTML, Sass compiled to CSS, and a small amount of vanilla JavaScript. It uses no frameworks.

The three required pages are:

Home, which introduces StoryCast, features one story, and lists all the others with filters and search.

Story page, which gives one story its own page with the media, a transcript, and related stories. Seven story pages share this template.

About / Access, which explains the mission, the editorial principles, and the accessibility commitments.

2. Research

I used desk research instead of surveys or interviews. I looked at three kinds of sources:

Reference sites. I studied StoryCorps (short animated stories), LibriVox (audiobooks read by volunteers), and a first draft of the concept built with an AI design tool. I looked at how they organise stories, label media, and present transcripts.

Accessibility guidance. I used the WCAG 2.1 AA success criteria as the standard, especially colour contrast, keyboard access, visible focus, captions and transcripts for time-based media, and heading structure.

Media sources and licences. I checked where stories, audio and video could come from legally: YouTube's embedded player, LibriVox (public domain in the USA) and Pixabay (Pixabay Content License).

What I learned from the research
People who cannot hear or see the media still need the story, so every story needs a text version next to it.
A story site works best when visitors can choose by category and search instead of scrolling through a long list.

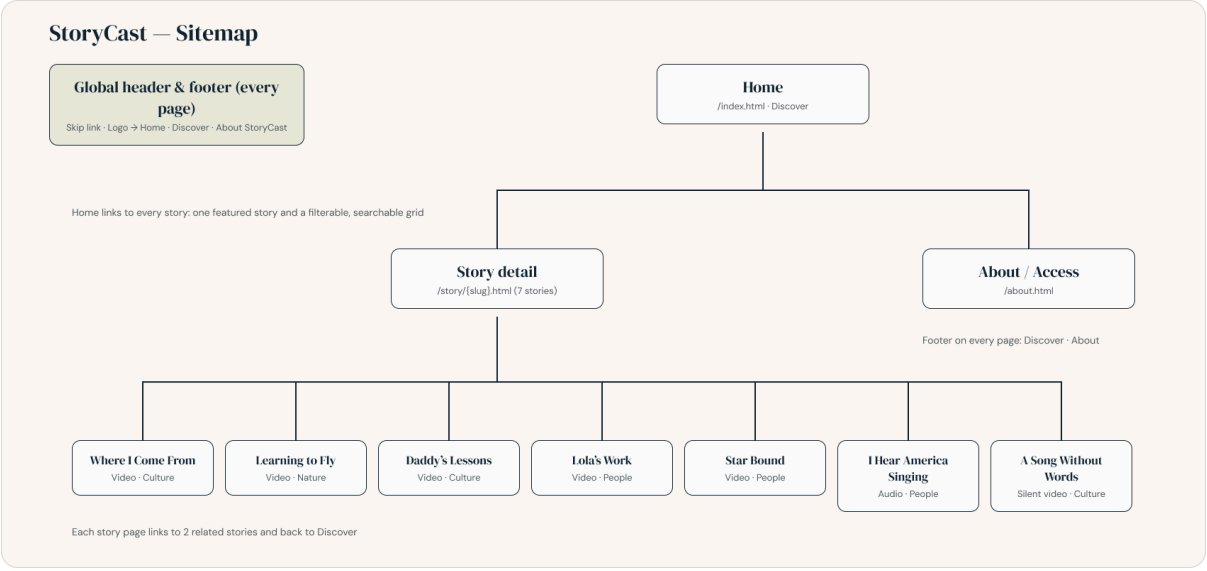
Playing media should always be the visitor's choice. Nothing should start by itself.
Sound-only stories need a written transcript, because browsers do not show captions for audio-only players.

Assumed users

These are design assumptions, not interview results.
A curious visitor who wants a short, moving story on a phone during a break.
A deaf or hard-of-hearing visitor who needs captions and transcripts.
A blind or low-vision visitor who uses a screen reader, keyboard or zoom and needs good structure and alt text.
A student or teacher who wants to find stories by theme and read them closely.

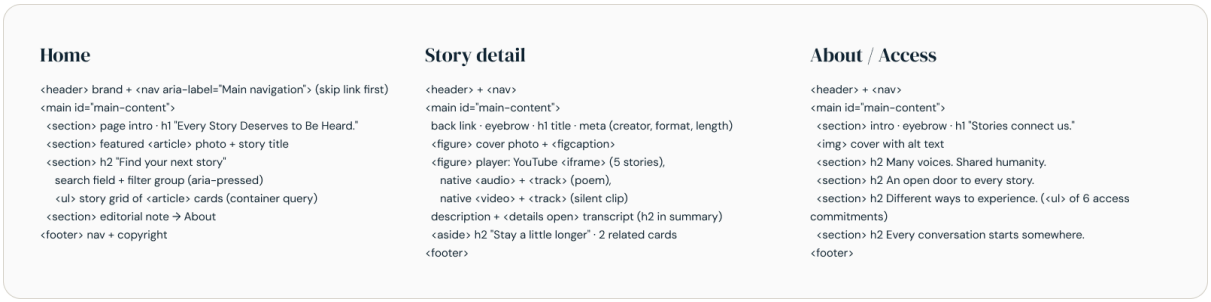
3. Information architecture

Sitemap



Every page carries the same header (brand, "Discover" and "About StoryCast") and the same footer links. Every story page links back to Discover and offers two related stories.

Hierarchy of each page



Home: page intro with the main heading, featured story, "Find your next story" with search and category filters, the story grid, and a closing note that links to About.

Story page: back link, category label, title, details (creator, format, length), the media player, the description, the transcript, and "Stay a little longer" with two related stories.
About: intro, cover photo, then four sections: mission, editorial principles, access commitments, and contact.

Navigation and labels
I kept the navigation to two clear destinations, because the site is small. Category names (Culture, People, Nature) are plain words. Link text says where it goes, such as "Back to Discover" and "The story behind StoryCast". A visitor can reach any story in two clicks from any page.

Content types
Five stories are YouTube videos with captions.
One story is an audio recording of a poem, read by a LibriVox volunteer.
One story is a short silent video with a written visual description.

4. Design process and decisions

Wireframes and mockups. I planned the layouts as wireframes first in Figma, then built high-fidelity mockups for Home, Story and About, plus a mobile Home. The Figma file also holds the sitemap, the page hierarchy, and the design tokens.

Design tokens. Colours, type, and spacing are defined once as tokens and reused everywhere:
Colours: a warm off-white background, deep navy text, terracotta for links and accents, sage green for labels and active filters, and a dark ink colour for the footer and player.
Typography: DM Serif Display for headings and DM Sans for body text.
Spacing and shape: a spacing scale from 4px to 96px, and small corner radii of 4, 6 and 8 pixels.

Layout. I used CSS Grid for the story grid and the About sections, and Flexbox for the header, filter bar, and card contents. A fluid grid and fluid heading sizes keep the layout working from small phones to wide desktops.

Container query. The story card is the main responsive component. It sits inside a container and changes its layout by the width of that container, not of the screen. When the container is 480 pixels wide or more, the image moves to the left and the text to the right. When it is narrower, the image sits above the text. The same card is used on Home and in the related-stories lists.

5. Technical implementation

Semantic HTML: Each page uses `header`, `nav`, `main`, `article`, `section`, `aside`, `figure`, `figcaption`, `details`, and `footer`. Each page has one `h1`, and the heading levels do not skip.
Sass architecture:

- Three token partials: `_colors.scss`, `_typography.scss` and `_spacing.scss`.
- A tokens file that turns them into CSS custom properties.
- Reset, base, layout, and utility partials, and one partial for each component.

`main.scss` imports all of them, and the compiled result is `css/main.css`.
BEM naming. Class names follow the block__element--modifier pattern, such as `card__title` and `site-nav__link`.
Cascade layers. The layers are declared once, in the order reset, tokens, base, layout, components, and utilities. Every partial puts its rules in its layer, so the layer order decides conflicts instead of specificity.
JavaScript. One small file adds category filtering and live search on Home, and highlights the line being read on the audio story page. The site works without it.
Media. The poem story uses a native `<audio>` element with a `<track>` caption file. The silent clip uses a native `<video>` element with a `<track>` caption file. The five YouTube stories use YouTube's embedded player, with captions switched on by default.

6. Accessibility

I designed toward WCAG 2.1 AA. The main measures are:

Colour contrast. Body text on the background is 14.7:1. Secondary text is 6.6:1. Links and accents are 6.4:1. Footer text is 13.2:1. The focus ring is 7.1:1. All of these are above the 4.5:1 required for text and 3:1 for interface parts.

Keyboard use. Every control is a real link, button, or input in a logical order. The first Tab stop on each page is a "Skip to main content" link.

Visible focus. A thick outline appears on anything focused. Story cards show the outline around the whole card.

Captions and transcripts. Each story page has a "Read the transcript" section directly below

the media. The audio story's transcript highlights the line being read.

Text alternatives. Every image has descriptive alt text. Decorative icons are hidden from screen readers. Photo captions say when a picture is a stand-in and not taken from the story.

ARIA only where needed. The active page uses `aria-current=" page"`, filter buttons use `aria-pressed`, the live story count uses `role=" status"`, and sections are labelled with `aria-labelledby`.

Media behaviour. Nothing plays automatically. Players are keyboard operable, and YouTube frames have descriptive titles.

Motion. Transitions are short and switch off for visitors who ask for reduced motion.

Limits. The site has not been independently audited or certified. Embedded YouTube players cannot take a `<track>` element, so their captions come from YouTube.

7. Testing

Keyboard: I tabbed through every page and could reach everything, and the focus ring was always visible.
Responsive: I checked the pages at 320, 600, 768, and 1280 pixels and at 200% zoom.
Container query: the card switched to the side-by-side layout at width.

8. Credits and licences

Videos: the five animated shorts are © StoryCorps, shown through YouTube's embedded player and not downloaded or changed.
Audio: "I Hear America Singing" by Walt Whitman, read by Zach Meissner for LibriVox, Short Poetry Collection 119. LibriVox recordings are public domain in the USA.
Video clip: "Guitarist, Acoustic Guitar" by Coverr-Free-Footage on Pixabay, used under the Pixabay Content License.
Fonts: DM Serif Display and DM Sans, loaded from Google Fonts.

9. Limitations and next steps

1. Replace stand-in photos with images that show the actual storytellers.
2. Host captions for the video stories so they can use the native video player.
3. Add more stories and more categories as the collection grows.